

A THREE-CHAPTER SCRIPTURE STUDY

THE APOSTLES OF ACTS

A Ministry to the Jews First



“to the Jew first, and also to the Greek”

— *Romans 1:16*

WITH THE SCRIPTURES QUOTED IN FULL
KING JAMES VERSION

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ALL SCRIPTURE QUOTATIONS FROM THE
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Introduction

The Book of Acts tells the story of the gospel going out from Jerusalem to the ends of the earth. But before it ever reached the nations, it was preached — deliberately, repeatedly, and first — to the Jewish people. The apostles began in the Temple, continued in the synagogues, and reasoned from the Law of Moses and the Prophets, because the Messiah they proclaimed was Israel's Messiah, promised to Israel's fathers.

This short study traces that pattern through the whole Book of Acts in three chapters: Pentecost in Jerusalem, the witness in the Temple and before the Council, and Paul's synagogue-first custom in every city. The scriptures are quoted in full so the text of the Bible itself makes the case.

Romans 1:16 — *For I am not ashamed of the gospel of Christ: for it is the power of God unto salvation to every one that believeth; to the Jew first, and also to the Greek.*

CHAPTER ONE

Pentecost: The Gospel Preached to the Men of Israel

Acts 1–2

The Book of Acts opens in Jerusalem, the heart of the Jewish world. The risen Lord commands the apostles to begin their witness there — among their own people — before going anywhere else.

Acts 1:8 — *But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me both in **Jerusalem**, and in all **Judaea**, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth.*

Notice the order: Jerusalem and Judaea — the Jewish homeland — come first. The mission does not begin with the nations; it begins with Israel.

The audience at Pentecost was Jewish

When the Holy Spirit fell on the day of Pentecost, the crowd that gathered was made up of Jews from every nation, in Jerusalem for the feast:

Acts 2:5 — *And there were dwelling at Jerusalem **Jews**, devout men, out of every nation under heaven.*

Peter's first sermon — the first gospel sermon of the church age — is addressed directly and explicitly to Jews:

Acts 2:14 — *But Peter, standing up with the eleven, lifted up his voice, and said unto them, **Ye men of Judaea**, and all ye that dwell at Jerusalem, be this known unto you, and hearken to my words.*

Acts 2:22 — ***Ye men of Israel**, hear these words; Jesus of Nazareth, a man approved of God among you by miracles and wonders and signs...*

Acts 2:36 — *Therefore let all the **house of Israel** know assuredly, that God hath made that same Jesus, whom ye have crucified, both Lord and Christ.*

The promise was to Israel and her children

When the crowd was cut to the heart and asked what to do, Peter's answer framed the promise in the language of Israel's covenants:

Acts 2:38–39 — *Then Peter said unto them, Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins, and ye shall receive the gift of the Holy Ghost. For the promise is **unto you, and to your children**, and to all that are afar off, even as many as the Lord our God shall call.*

Three thousand souls were added that day (Acts 2:41) — and every one of them was a Jew or a proselyte to Judaism (Acts 2:10). The church was born entirely Jewish.

CHAPTER TWO

In the Temple and Before the Council: Israel Called to Repentance

Acts 3–7

After Pentecost the apostles did not leave Judaism behind. They kept the Jewish hours of prayer and made the Temple in Jerusalem their base of ministry.

Acts 3:1 — *Now Peter and John went up together into the temple at the hour of prayer, being the ninth hour.*

“Ye men of Israel” — Peter’s second sermon

After the healing of the lame man at the Beautiful Gate, Peter again preaches directly to the Jewish people, calling them by their covenant names:

Acts 3:12 — *And when Peter saw it, he answered unto the people, **Ye men of Israel**, why marvel ye at this?*

Acts 3:13 — *The God of Abraham, and of Isaac, and of Jacob, the God of **our fathers**, hath glorified his Son Jesus...*

Peter tells them plainly that they are the heirs of the prophets and of the covenant, and that the risen Christ was sent **to them first**:

Acts 3:25–26 — ***Ye are the children of the prophets, and of the covenant** which God made with our fathers, saying unto Abraham, And in thy seed shall all the kindreds of the earth be blessed. **Unto you first** God, having raised up his Son Jesus, sent him to bless you, in turning away every one of you from his iniquities.*

This is one of the clearest statements in all of Acts: “Unto you first.” The blessing of the risen Messiah was offered to the Jews before anyone else.

Witness before the rulers of Israel

Arrested and brought before the Sanhedrin — the highest Jewish court — the apostles preach Christ to the leaders of the nation:

Acts 4:8, 10 — *Ye rulers of the people, and elders of **Israel**... Be it known unto you all, and to all the people of **Israel**, that by the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth... doth this man stand here before you whole.*

Acts 5:30–31 — *The God of **our fathers** raised up Jesus, whom ye slew and hanged on a tree. Him hath God exalted with his right hand to be a Prince and a Saviour, for to give repentance to **Israel**, and forgiveness of sins.*

Even under threat, the apostles never stopped teaching the Jewish people:

Acts 5:42 — *And daily in the **temple**, and in every house, they ceased not to teach and preach Jesus Christ.*

Stephen: Israel's whole story retold

Stephen's defense in Acts 7 — the longest speech in the book — is a retelling of the entire history of Israel: Abraham (7:2), Joseph (7:9), Moses (7:20), the wilderness (7:36), David and Solomon (7:45–47). His sermon assumes Jewish hearers who know the scriptures, and it ends with the prophets' own charge to the nation:

Acts 7:51–52 — *Ye stiffnecked and uncircumcised in heart and ears, ye do always resist the Holy Ghost: as **your fathers** did, so do ye. Which of the **prophets** have not your fathers persecuted?*

Through seven chapters of Acts, the gospel has gone to no one but Jews, proselytes, and the house of Israel.

CHAPTER THREE

“To the Jew First”: Paul’s Synagogue Pattern in Every City

Acts 9–28

Even Paul — famously the apostle to the Gentiles (Romans 11:13) — began his ministry in **every single city** at the Jewish synagogue. This was not an accident; it was his settled custom.

The pattern begins at his conversion

Acts 9:20 — *And straightway he preached Christ in the synagogues, that he is the Son of God.*

Antioch of Pisidia: the pattern stated plainly

In Acts 13, Paul enters the synagogue on the sabbath and addresses the congregation:

Acts 13:16 — *Then Paul stood up, and beckoning with his hand said, **Men of Israel**, and ye that fear God, give audience.*

Acts 13:26 — *Men and brethren, **children of the stock of Abraham**, and whosoever among you feareth God, to you is the word of this salvation sent.*

And when many Jews rejected the message, Paul declared the principle that governed his whole ministry:

Acts 13:46 — *Then Paul and Barnabas waxed bold, and said, It was necessary that the word of God should **first have been spoken to you**: but seeing ye put it from you, and judge yourselves unworthy of everlasting life, lo, we turn to the Gentiles.*

“It was necessary... *first to you.*” The Jews had the first claim on the gospel.

City after city, synagogue first

The pattern repeats without exception through Paul’s journeys:

Iconium — Acts 14:1 — *And it came to pass in Iconium, that they went both together into the **synagogue of the Jews**, and so spake, that a great multitude both of the **Jews** and also of the Greeks believed.*

Thessalonica — Acts 17:1–2 — ...where was a *synagogue of the Jews*: and Paul, **as his manner was**, went in unto them, and three sabbath days reasoned with them out of the *scriptures*.

Berea — Acts 17:10–11 — ...went into the *synagogue of the Jews*. These were more noble than those in Thessalonica, in that they received the word with all readiness of mind, and **searched the scriptures daily**, whether those things were so.

Corinth — Acts 18:4–5 — And he reasoned in the *synagogue* every sabbath... Paul was pressed in the spirit, and testified to the *Jews* that Jesus was Christ.

Ephesus — Acts 19:8 — And he went into the *synagogue*, and spake boldly for the space of three months, disputing and persuading the things concerning the kingdom of God.

Luke's phrase in Acts 17:2 — "**as his manner was**" — tells us this was Paul's deliberate, consistent practice.

The hope of Israel, to the very last chapter

Even as a prisoner in Rome, in the final chapter of Acts, Paul's first act is to call together **the chief of the Jews**:

Acts 28:17 — *And it came to pass, that after three days Paul called the **chief of the Jews** together...*

Acts 28:20 — *...because that for the **hope of Israel** I am bound with this chain.*

Acts 28:23 — *...he expounded and testified the kingdom of God, persuading them concerning Jesus, both out of the **law of Moses**, and out of the **prophets**, from morning till evening.*

From the upper room in Jerusalem (Acts 1) to a rented house in Rome (Acts 28), the apostles of Acts carried the gospel to the Jewish people first — in the Temple, in the synagogues, out of the Law and the Prophets — because, as Paul wrote:

Romans 1:16 — *For I am not ashamed of the gospel of Christ: for it is the power of God unto salvation to every one that believeth; **to the Jew first**, and also to the Greek.*

Summary of Key Scriptures

Theme	Scripture
Witness begins in Jerusalem and Judaea	Acts 1:8
Pentecost crowd: devout Jews	Acts 2:5, 14, 22, 36
The promise to Israel and her children	Acts 2:38–39
“Unto you first” — Christ sent to Israel	Acts 3:25–26
Repentance given to Israel	Acts 5:30–31
Stephen retells Israel’s history	Acts 7:2–53
Paul preaches in the synagogues at once	Acts 9:20
“First spoken to you”	Acts 13:16, 26, 46
“As his manner was” — synagogue in every city	Acts 14:1; 17:1–2, 10; 18:4–5; 19:8
“The hope of Israel,” Law and Prophets	Acts 28:17, 20, 23
“To the Jew first”	Romans 1:16